

Blue tit

Cyanistes caeruleus

- ↔ 5 in (13 cm)
- 📍 Europe, N. Africa, Middle East, parts of Central Asia
- ⊗ Common

Mainly yellow below, the blue tit has a bright blue cap and greenish blue wings and tail; the blue of a breeding male's plumage is brighter than that of the female. It is naturally a woodland bird, but is widespread on farmland and in backyards. Pairs may raise large broods of up to 16 in tree holes, but the survival of

the young depends on a continuous supply of caterpillars—each nestling can eat up to 100 caterpillars a day. Both parents help to feed the young, making several excursions a day to collect food.

greenish blue upperparts



House martin

Delichon urbicum

- ↔ 5 in (13 cm)
- 📍 Africa, Europe, SE. and northern Asia
- ⊗ Common

Closely related to the swallows, this small, highly aerial, black-and-white bird is a common sight in European towns in summer, where small groups gather to swoop and dive in pursuit of airborne insects. It usually nests on buildings, high up beneath overhangs that provide shelter from the rain; the nest is a cup built from pellets of mud attached to the wall. At the end of summer, it migrates to Africa.

Eurasian skylark

Alauda arvensis

- ↔ 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa, Europe, parts of Asia; introduced to Australia and New Zealand
- ⊗ Common

Celebrated for its liquid, silvery song, performed while rising high in the air on fluttering wings, the skylark is a common grassland bird across most of Eurasia, although its numbers have declined due to changes in farming regimes. Its streaky brown plumage makes it inconspicuous on the ground, where it nests in the shelter of a grass tussock or similar cover.

Eurasian wren

Troglodytes troglodytes

- ↔ 3 in (8 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, N. Africa
- ⊗ Common

This tiny, brown, short-tailed wren is frequently seen darting between shrubs on whirring wings or searching for insect prey among dense thickets near the ground. The male draws attention with his pugnacious posturing, bobbing his head with his tail cocked and delivering an astonishingly loud song for his size. In winter, wrens often gather in communal night roosts to keep warm.

Eurasian nuthatch

Sitta europaea

- ↔ 6 in (15 cm)
- 📍 Europe, C. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

This small woodland bird uses its powerful bill to probe for insects in tree bark and hammer into nuts. It is very agile, climbing up and down tree trunks and branches with distinctive jerky movements, clinging on with its sharp claws and often descending head first. Blue-gray above with rich buff underparts and a black streak through its eye, it often gives itself away with loud, fluting calls.



Northern mockingbird

Mimus polyglottos

- ↔ 10 in (26 cm)
- 📍 North America, Mexico
- ⊗ Common

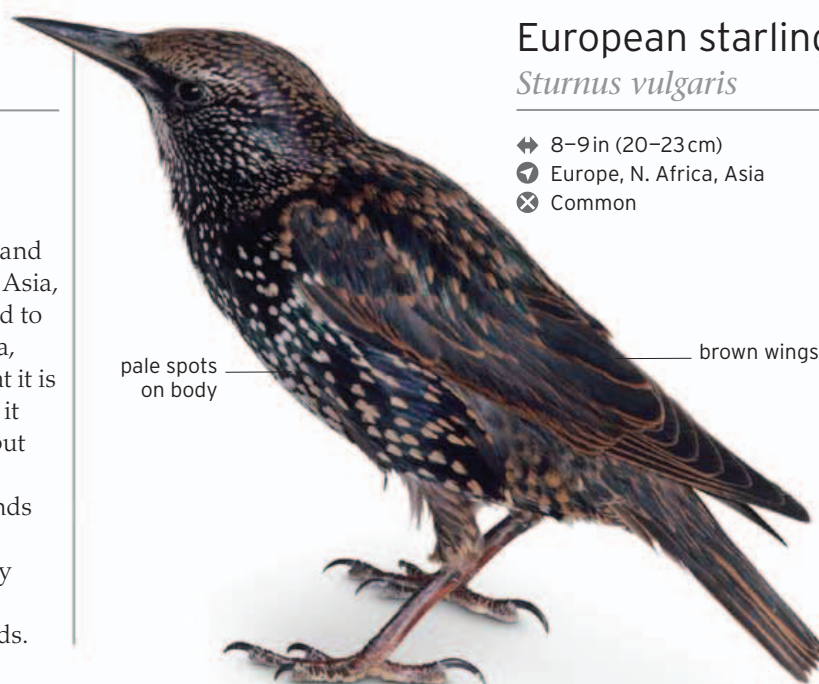
Mainly gray with paler underparts and a white bar across each wing, the northern mockingbird possesses remarkable vocal skills. It has a wide repertoire, made up of original phrases combined with mimicry of almost anything it hears, from other birds to sounds such as car alarms; it typically repeats each phrase several times. It thrives in a variety of habitats from semideserts to city centers.

Common myna

Acridotheres tristis

- ↔ 10 in (25 cm)
- 📍 Southern Asia
- ⊗ Common

This dark, yellow-billed grassland starling is a native of southern Asia, but has been widely introduced to other regions such as Australia, where it is now so common that it is considered a pest. In the wild, it eats fruit, seeds, and insects, but it is an adaptable opportunist, scavenging for scraps of all kinds in towns. At dusk it gathers in large tree roosts, calling noisily with a cacophony of gurgling, squawking, and clicking sounds.



European starling

Sturnus vulgaris

- ↔ 8–9 in (20–23 cm)
- 📍 Europe, N. Africa, Asia
- ⊗ Common

Common, widespread, and invasive, the European starling has spread to every continent (except Antarctica), in some cases through deliberate introduction. In North America, for example, 60 birds released in 1890 have multiplied to an estimated 150 million. Glossy iridescent black in summer, with pale spots in winter, the starling is a swaggering, quarrelsome, yet sociable bird that feeds in flocks, often probing the ground for insect grubs. It forms huge communal roosts, preceded at dusk by spectacular mass aerial displays resembling clouds of smoke. In the wild, these birds are hole-nesters, although they also nest in buildings and nest boxes.